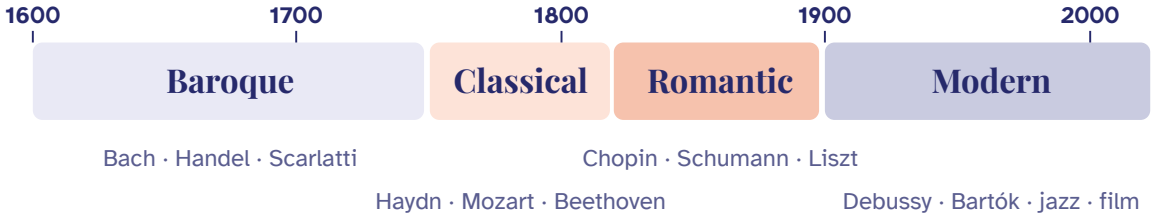
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 6

Styles through time

Music changes with its time, like clothes and buildings. Four big periods cover most piano music. Each has a sound you can learn to recognise, and a way it likes to be played.

THE SECRET

Listen for the texture, the ornaments and the pedal: they tell you the century.



Four centuries, four sounds

PERIOD	LISTEN FOR
Baroque 1600–1750	harpsichord and organ; two or more tunes woven together; many ornaments; loud or soft in blocks; a steady beat throughout
Classical 1750–1820	the new piano; a clear tune with an Alberti bass; tidy 4-bar phrases; crescendos and contrasts
Romantic 1820–1900	big feelings; rich chords and the pedal; rubato; the whole keyboard, from very soft to very loud
Modern 1900–today	new scales and harmonies, surprising rhythms; impressionism, jazz, minimalism, film music

Playing in style

	PEDAL	TIME	TOUCH
Baroque	little or none	steady	clear, often detached
Classical	light	steady	neat, even, singing tune
Romantic	rich	rubato	deep, legato
Modern	as marked	as marked	whatever the music asks

LISTEN FOR IT

Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach
Minuet in G (Petzold)
two lines, a steady dance

Mozart
Sonata in C, K. 545
Alberti bass, clear phrases

Chopin
Nocturnes
a singing tune, rubato, pedal

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which period?

A tune over an Alberti bass, tidy 4-bar phrases ?

1. **Alberti bass:** which period did it belong to?
2. **Tidy phrases**, question and answer.
3. **So?**

Classical: think Mozart.

EXAMPLE 2

Which period?

Two equal tunes, many trills, written for harpsichord ?

1. **Two tunes woven together**: which texture?
2. **Harpsichord**, before the piano.
3. **So?**

Baroque: think Bach.

EXAMPLE 3

Which period?

Rubato, rich pedalled chords, huge leaps across the keyboard ?

1. **Rubato**: time stretched for feeling.
2. **Rich chords** held in the pedal.
3. **So?**

Romantic: think Chopin.

GAME

Who belongs where?

1	2	3	4
Bach	Mozart	Chopin	Debussy

Match each composer to a period.

Answer: 1 Baroque · 2 Classical · 3 Romantic · 4 Modern.

TRAP

- × Pedalling Bach like Chopin: Baroque music needs little or no pedal.
- × Romantic rubato in Mozart: keep Classical time steady.

SEE ALSO
Ornaments p. 88 · The pedals p. 85

PRACTISE IT
Online: Library › Styles